

YEAR
2008

Fear was the KEY

It was the year when, as in cricket, politics too became a game of glorious uncertainties. Fear of defeat drove the UPA to reach out to the SP while votebank politics compelled the Congress to go back on its earlier stand on a tough anti-terror law.

SIFRA DAS



CRISIS OF CONFIDENCE

The frequent jabs from the Left saw the UPA Government spend the first half of the year in fear of being voted out in Parliament. Four Left parties vowed to pull the plug if **Manmohan Singh** went ahead with the Indo-US nuclear deal, on which the prime minister had staked a lot. Enter the Samajwadi Party, which like the Congress, didn't want an early general election. Both **Mulayam Singh** and **Amar Singh** mollified the party's minority votebank by quoting APJ Abdul Kalam's endorsement of the N-deal and backed the Government which won the trust vote. But it still remains so unsure of its hastily cobbled support that when a bill comes for parliamentary passage, ministers keep their fingers crossed.



AP

YASBANT NEGI



PRIMED AND READY

NDA's prime minister-in-waiting L. K. Advani has a good mascot in Sharad Yadav, who replaces George Fernandes as the NDA convener. It took four months of shrewd politicking for Advani to bring in Yadav and trump Bihar chief minister's candidature as Nitish Kumar could have emerged as an aspirant for the top job. The 81-year-old Advani knows that this could be his last chance at prime ministership. He recently launched a website devoted to himself. His poll plank is 'Tough on Terror'. Both the medium and the message are ready. But will it work? Advani fervently hopes so.

POLITICAL EVENTS